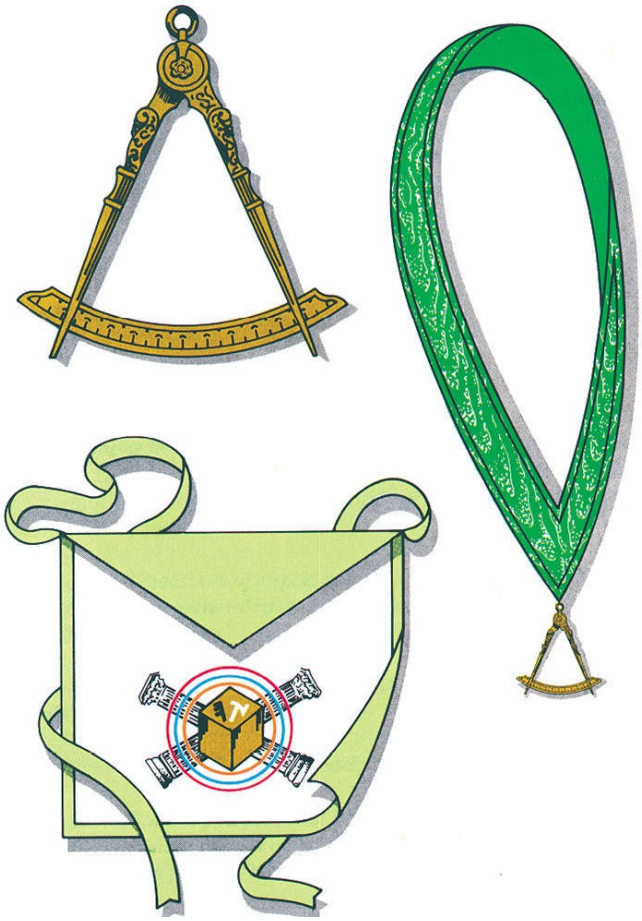
The 5th Degree – Perfect Master



The apron is of white lambskin. The lining, border and flap are light green. Two crossed columns with three concentric circles and a golden cube superimposed form the center design of the apron. The outside circle is crimson, the center one blue and the inner one orange. There are two letters upon the top face of the cube; the one on the left black and the other white. The cube represents the finite universe and the three circles symbolize the wisdom, power and beneficence of God; the great trinity of His attributes. The letters יה (yod, heh) are Phoenician and are the first two letters of the ancient name of God.

The jewel is the compasses, opened to sixty degrees, the points on a graduated arc. Masonic compasses are opened to sixty degrees because this is the number of degrees in each of the three angles of an equilateral triangle, always a symbol of Deity. It is suspended from a broad grass–green watered ribbon worn from the right shoulder to the left hip. This jewel, absent the square, indicates that the

candidate is moving away from the earthly and toward the heavenly: “[The Square] ... is an emblem of what concerns the earth and the body; [the Compasses] of what concerns the heavens and the soul” (p. 11). The color of the ribbon symbolizes the attainment of this transition by the renewal of virtue.

DUTIES

Be industrious and honest.

LESSONS

Life is uncertain; death may call at any time.

The noblest portion of humanity is virtue for virtue’s sake.

FOR REFLECTION

Can you measure your age, not by years, but by good deeds?

Does a life well lived prepare one for death?

IMPORTANT SYMBOLS

Branches of acacia, coffin, the Master Hiram.

Custom and practice from 1883 to 1935 required the candidate to prepare a last will and testament while in the preparation room of this degree. Now he may or may not prepare a will. The purpose of writing a will, or contemplating doing so, is to impress upon the candidate the uncertainty of life. Death may call at any time and it is the duty of every Mason to provide for his family and loved ones.

CEREMONY

The lodge is no longer in deep mourning but is still in sorrow, indicated by the altar cover of black cloth with silver tears. The ceremony takes place on the anniversary of the death of the Master Hiram. This annual tribute, according to legend, was ordered by King Solomon and re–enacts the burial of that Perfect Master.

The principal characters are: Adoniram ben Abada who, after the death of Hiram, was appointed Chief Architect of the Temple, Zabud ben Nathan as the Prime Minister, King Solomon and King Hiram of Tyre.

While in the preparation room, the candidate is asked to answer in writing a number of questions concerned primarily with his perception of his duty to God, his fellow men and himself.

As in the 3rd Degree of the Symbolic Lodge, the candidate again represents the deceased Master Hiram and his entrance into the lodge reinforces this identification. During his entrance, Adoniram and Zabud recite two verses of commemorative poetry:

Our ancient Brethren whelm"d in grief,
Lamented their departed chief!
Let us, his pupils long revere
A name to memory so dear—as Hiram Abif.

In mystic rites our Lodge displays
its sorrows and its fadeless praise:
Long may the sweet acacia bloom,
And garlands fresh adorn the tomb—of Hiram Abif.

The instruction of this degree is based on the certainty of death:

While we think a thought, we die ...
Death is the portion of every man

The Master Hiram is an example to be imitated, a man who led a wise and virtuous life. We should always keep our houses in order for we know not when our journey upon this earth shall end. We should ask God's aid to live well, that we may die well.

During the funeral ceremony, a moving poem urges us to consider how old we are, not by years, but

"How old art thou?" – man measureth Time
By things that fall away and die.
By sickled fields of autumn–prime,
Summer's last bloom or winter's sky.

The true heart never can grow old,
Its eye is bright when youth has fled;
Its ear is never dull or cold;
Its lips can speak, though speech be dead.

By prayer, by alms, by written page,
By sowing words of holy trust,
It quickeneth life from age to age,
And liveth when the flesh is dust.

So count thou not thine age by tears,
Or hours of Fortune's fleeting day,
Nor count how old thou art in years,
Of waste, and folly, and decay.

But keeping still thy steadfast eye
On God, from whom thy life proceeds,
Notch thou its seasons on the soul,
And tell its calendar by deeds.

Kings Solomon and Hiram attend the funeral ceremony. Their discussion is a reminder that we shall never be able to live over again any of those days and months which have passed.

We learn: the burial of a brother should be done gravely, decently and charitably. What is done to the dead, and the living for their sakes, comes from a sense of gratitude, and virtue for virtue's sake is the noblest portion of humanity.

The square, compasses, gavel and rule, emblems of the virtues and authority of the deceased, are placed upon the coffin. Branches of acacia are given to all the brothers and are symbolic of immortality and, as explained in the *Legenda*, "of that life of innocence and purity for which the Faithful hope..." *(Legenda 4°–14°*, pp. 12–13).

And then, being placed at the altar as a Perfect Master, Hiram serves to remind the candidate of his hope to revive in virtue. Green, the symbolic color of this

degree seen in the apron, also represents this renewal of virtue.

The final instruction to the candidate concerns the apron, collar and jewel. These items are representative of the Master Hiram and remind us to always make him a model for our conduct that at our death we may deserve the honors paid to him.

LECTURE

In *Morals and Dogma* Pike expands upon the practice of honesty and industry so that upon death, whenever that should be, others may look upon us, and we may look upon ourselves, as having accomplished as much as possible honestly.

Industry:

Idleness is the burial of a living man. For an idle person is so useless to any purposes of God and man, that he is like one who is dead, unconcerned in the changes and necessities of the world; and he only lives to spend his time, and eat the fruits of the earth. Like a vermin or a wolf, when his time comes, he dies and perishes, and in the meantime is nought (p. 114).

We think, at the age of twenty, that life is much too long for that which we have to learn and do; ... But when, at the age of sixty... we halt, and look back along the way we have come, and cast up and endeavor to balance our accounts with time and opportunity, we find that we have made life much too short, and thrown away a huge portion of our time (p. 115).

To learn and to do!–this is the soul's work here below. The soul grows truly as an oak grows (p. 115).

To sleep little, and to study much; to say little, and to hear and think much; to learn, that we may be able to do, and then do, earnestly and vigorously, whatever may be required of us by duty, and by the good of our fellows, our country, and mankind,—these are the duties of every Mason who desires to imitate the Master [Hiram] (p. 116).

Honesty:

The duty of a Mason as an honest man is plain and easy. It requires of us honesty in contract, sincerity in affirming, simplicity in bargaining, and faithfulness in performing (p. 116).

Lie not at all, neither in a little thing nor in a great, neither in substance nor in the circumstance, neither in the word nor deed: ....A Perfect Master must avoid that which deceives, equally with that which is false (p. 116).

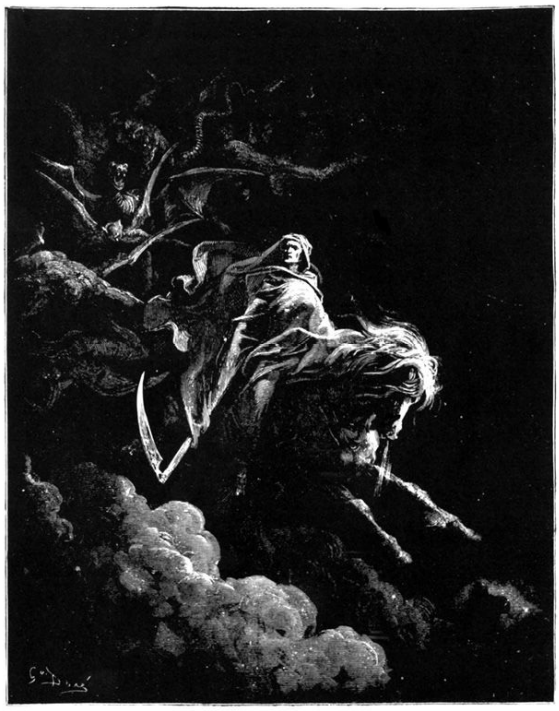
That any man should be the worse for us, [by both act and intention] ... *is against the rule of equity, of justice, and of charity* (p. 117).

It should be the earnest desire of every Perfect Master so to live and deal and act... that no man on earth is poorer, because he is richer... (p. 117).

Be careful, then, that thou receive no wages, here or elsewhere, that are not your due! (p. 118).



Artistic representations of death vary from the whimsical, such as the above 15th-century woodcut, to the sober, illustrated by Dore's Death on a Pale Horse, shown on the following page and inspired by Revelation 6:8.



Death on a Pale Horse
by Gustave Dore